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Politics - April 3 election poised to be big - L.A.-area turnout, backing for women could point to trends

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Author: Kevin Modesti | Section: News | 1043 Words
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Already anticipating high-stakes state and congressional races later this year, California politics-watchers might overlook next week's elections to fill three empty Assembly seats in the Los Angeles area.

Maybe they should pay more attention.

The April 3 special elections mark the first round of voting in 2018 in Southern California, and they might tell a lot about what to expect from future contests in a year when many of the region's congressional races carry the potential to reshape national politics.

Political observers say they'll be watching the special elections for clues about several trends:

• How female candidates will fare in the wake of sexual-harass

ment scandals, including incidents in Sacramento that created two of the Assembly openings by prompting the resignations of San Fernando Valley Democrats Raul Bocanegra and Matt Dababneh.

• Whether progressive Democrats, or moderate Democrats, run stronger in a year of party infighting following Hillary Clinton's presidential election defeat.

• And whether liberal voters will be as enthusiastic as forecast in California's first bunch of elections since Donald Trump's inauguration.

"If our people are showing up for every election, that's got to bode well for the future," said Zack Czajkowski, who is campaign manager for Katie Hill, one of the Democrats running for Congress against Republican Rep. Steve Knight of Santa Clarita.

Czajkowski said he's watching the April Assembly elections, which normally would attract only local interest, for clues about how women and progressive candidates — such as Hill — will do in the June 5 primary and the Nov. 6 general election.

Valerie McGinty, founder and president of Fund Her, an organization that raises money to elect progressive women to California state offices, said she has high hopes for the group's endorsed candidates in the three Assembly special elections: Luz Rivas, Tricia Robbins Kasson and Sydney Kamlager.

"I think there's a very good chance for all three of these candidates," McGinty said.

She thinks they could create momentum for women to pick up as many as 10 seats that have been held by men in the Assembly and Senate, raising women's share of the state Legislature from the present 22 percent.

The prominence of women candidates is something the three April elections have in common.

• In Assembly District 39, which includes the northeast San Fernando Valley communities of Arleta, Lake View Terrace, Mission Hills, North Hollywood, Pacoima, Sun Valley, Sunland-Tujunga, Sylmar and San Fernando, the six candidates to serve the remaining months of Bocanegra's term include four women. The winner almost certainly

will come from among five Democrats.

Union-backed Antonio Sanchez is the race's leading fundraiser, but Rivas, the MIT- and Harvard-educated founder of a local nonprofit that supports girls' science and technology education, has endorsements from the California Democratic Party and L.A. Mayor Eric Garcetti, and Patty Lopez can tap into the support that gave her an upset win over Bocanegra in 2014 before Bocanegra won back the Assembly seat in 2016.

• In AD 45, Robbins Kasson is the only women among eight candidates to replace Dababneh in representing the west San Fernando Valley communities of Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana and Encino and the Ventura County community of Bell Canyon.

That should give Robbins Kasson, an aide to L.A. City Councilman Bob Blumenfield, a mathematical advantage because voters who favor women in the year of #MeToo are likely to choose her. But to win, she'll have to overcome heavy fundraising by fellow Democrat Jesse Gabriel, an attorney endorsed by the Democratic Party of the San Fernando Valley. An X factor is Dennis Zine, a well-known former L.A. city councilman who dropped out of the race but remains on the ballot, listed as an independent, one of two non-Democrats.

• In AD 54, two Democratic women lead the way in fundraising and endorsements among four candidates to replace Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who cited health problems in his resignation, representing parts of L.A. and West L.A. as well as Culver City and Inglewood.

It seems virtually certain that Kamlager, president of the L.A. Community College District Board of Trustees, or Tepring Piquado, a neuroscientist and Rand Corp. policy analyst, will win the seat. Kamlager leads in fundraising and endorsements, with U.S. Sen. Kamala Harris her most powerful backer.

In each special election, any candidate who earns an outright majority of votes April 3 will be sworn in to serve until Dec. 3. Otherwise, the top two will advance to a runoff June 5.

Perhaps confusingly for voters, June 5 is also the day of the primary for the next full two-year term.

So the same ballot booklet could include two separate races in the same district, the special-election runoff to decide who serves the remainder of the current terms and the primary to determine which two candidates advance to the Nov. 6 general election.

Some observers say it will be risky to draw conclusions from the special-election results because of the brevity of the campaigns, the Democratic leanings of the three districts, the sexual-misconduct scandals giving extra energy to women candidates, and the differences in scale between races for state Legislature and Congress.

It's also likely that voter turnout will be much lower in April than it will be in June.

"I don't find them particularly relevant ," said Nicole DeMont, campaign manager for Bryan Caforio, one of Katie Hill's Democrat rivals in the congressional race against Steve Knight. The Knight-held seat is one of a half-dozen in Southern California that Democrats hope to pick up in a national effort to capture control of the House.

But others say April 3 could be telling precisely because turnout is expected to be so low.

In the past five years, stand-alone special elections for state Legislature seats in L.A. County have drawn between 6.2 percent and 10.3 percent of registered voters.

If turnouts rise over 10 percent this time, it could be a sign that Democrats are unusually fired up.

If that happens, campaign strategists for June and November races might change their assumptions about who is and isn't going to vote, and broaden the targets for their messages.

For now, the easy trend to watch is how women candidates fare and whether women voters turn out more than usual. Seven women are among 18 candidates in the special elections — a higher percentage than usual.

kmodesti@scng.com @KevinModesti on Twitter

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